MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 1: Elizabethan England and William Shakespeare

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Shakespeare’s writing grew out of a particular world of rulers, religious debate, travelling stories, professional actors, and paying audiences.

Start with a picture

Imagine a busy outdoor theatre. Some people stand close to the stage; others sit in galleries. Performers have few painted backgrounds, so words must help the audience imagine a castle, storm, or battlefield. A play is a shared event, not simply a book read alone.

1. The historical world

Elizabeth I ruled from 1558 to 1603; James I succeeded her. Shakespeare’s career crosses both reigns. Renaissance humanism encouraged education and classical learning. Religious changes and political concerns made authority, succession, loyalty, and conscience urgent subjects.

Do not assume that every speech supports the government. Plays can stage conflicting positions without delivering one simple political message.

2. Shakespeare’s life and working career

William Shakespeare lived from 1564 to 1616. He came from Stratford-upon-Avon and worked in London as an actor, playwright, and company shareholder. His company was known as the Lord Chamberlain’s Men and later the King’s Men. His career was connected to theatrical business, not only private inspiration.

The gaps in surviving records are genuine gaps, not proof that another person wrote the plays. Keep documentary evidence separate from speculation.

3. Making a play required many people

Actors, writers, patrons, theatre owners, and officials shaped performance. Censorship, associated with the Master of the Revels, could affect what reached the stage. Plague closures interrupted performances and income. Collaboration and revision were normal theatrical practices.

Shakespeare adapted chronicles, classical stories, earlier drama, and Italian narratives. Borrowing a plot did not remove originality: selection, language, characterisation, and theatrical arrangement transformed it.

4. Actors and audiences

Professional English public companies used male performers, including boys in female roles. This makes a disguised heroine such as Viola especially interesting: a male performer played a woman who performed a male identity within the story.

Audiences included people of different occupations and resources. Ticket arrangements created social differences within the same theatre. It is misleading to imagine every spectator responding in one way.

5. Stage conditions influence writing

An open stage, daylight, entrances, an upper playing area, and limited scenery encouraged flexible transitions. Spoken description could establish location. Soliloquies and asides could create a close relationship with spectators. Indoor venues had different conditions; “Elizabethan theatre” was not one unchanging building.

6. How the texts survive

A **quarto** and a **folio** describe formats produced by folding printed sheets differently. They are not quality grades. The 1623 First Folio, associated with John Heminges and Henry Condell, collected thirty-six plays after Shakespeare’s death. Some plays also survive in earlier quartos.

Different witnesses can contain different readings. Editors compare them, choose a base text, and sometimes make an **emendation**, a proposed correction. Your edition is therefore the result of decisions, not a window onto an untouched original manuscript.

Key words

- **Patronage:** support and protection from influential people.
- **Company:** a professional group of performers.
- **Textual witness:** a surviving document containing a version of a work.
- **Emendation:** an editorial correction proposed for a text.

Quick check

1. Did Shakespeare work only under Elizabeth? **No; his career continued under James I.**
2. Does a borrowed story mean an unoriginal play? **No; dramatic transformation matters.**
3. Is the First Folio a collection prepared by Shakespeare himself in 1623? **No; it appeared after his death.**

Build an exam answer

1. Introduce theatre as a working institution.
2. Explain patronage, censorship, and closures.
3. Connect stage features to one scene or device.
4. Distinguish quarto, folio, and editorial decisions.
5. Conclude with the interaction of imagination and conditions.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not equate folio with a perfect text or quarto with a pirated text. Do not use the word Elizabethan to erase the Jacobean part of Shakespeare’s career.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Explain how theatrical conditions and textual transmission shape our understanding of Shakespeare.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Shakespeare’s drama should be understood as the product of an institution as well as an individual imagination. Professional companies needed plays that could be rehearsed, performed, and sold to audiences. Patronage offered protection, while censorship and plague closures imposed limits. These conditions affected the opportunities available to writers without mechanically determining every dramatic meaning.

The physical stage provided expressive possibilities. Its relative openness allowed rapid movement between fictional locations, while language helped spectators construct settings. An aside could let the audience know what other characters did not, and a soliloquy could transform spectators into witnesses of private uncertainty. Such devices work through the relationship between performer and audience, not through language alone. A discussion of stagecraft should therefore connect a physical condition with a particular dramatic effect.

The survival of printed versions introduces another dimension. Quartos and the First Folio preserve texts that sometimes differ in wording, length, and arrangement. Modern editors must decide how to present those differences. A reader comparing editions may consequently encounter different line numbers or passages. Recognising this does not make interpretation impossible; it makes accurate reference and editorial awareness essential.

A balanced answer connects historical context, performance, and textual evidence. It avoids treating the plays either as direct political documents or as creations entirely detached from the working world. Shakespeare’s achievement becomes clearer when invention is studied alongside the collaborative and material circumstances that made it possible.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. Write an essay discussing the influence of Renaissance humanism on Shakespeare’s portrayal of characters.
2. Explain the effects of Elizabethan political and religious conditions on the content of Shakespeare’s plays.
3. Describe the structure and features of Elizabethan theatres and their influence on Shakespeare’s drama.
4. Compare and contrast quartos and folios in the preservation of Shakespeare’s works.
5. Analyse the role of collaboration in Shakespeare’s career and its impact on his plays.